

At AWWB we believe sharing is part of the art. We welcome the wisdom of others when we invite participants to voice their truth and honor what is being said. While facilitating an art workshop there will be many opportunities for participants to share. During these moments, it's important to be aware of where your own heart, thoughts and levels of self-care are at in order to have an authentic and thoughtful response that is true to you while also serving the highest good of the participant.

It takes a lot of strength to share and be your most genuine self with others. Likewise it takes courage to bear witness to what is being said, especially when the content addresses challenging topics or trauma. Our aim is to co-create a window of time for participants to connect and notice they have support. We encourage you to consider the following to help create an inviting, supportive and responsive workshop space.

Try Open-Ended Questions: *Asking open-ended questions can invite participants to process their feelings and thoughts regarding their creation rather than focusing on the appearance. It can also help us avoid making assumptions regarding what the participant created or what it means to them. A few open-ended questions you can use are:*

- If your art could speak, what would it say?
- What does this mean to you?
- What story are you telling?

Use Non-Verbal Cues: *The way you listen, move, and react can communicate whether you are listening, care, or being truthful. Some non-verbal cues that can express that you are connecting with what a participant shared include:*

- Placing a hand on your heart
- Using a solidarity snap(s)
- Use the ASL sign for applause (waving your hands in the air) to provide support and encouragement
- Reacting with emojis, if you are facilitating virtually

Getting out of our heads and into our hearts: *We invite you to steer away from commenting on the participant's art, but rather focus on the present moment and what the participant is feeling. Doing so can help you and the participants get out of your heads and into your hearts. To do this we invite you to:*

- **Using Reflections:** Reflect back anything that the participant said or stood out to you, such as their facial expressions or words they used to describe their art.
 - *For example: "I noticed you started to smile when you mentioned your grandparents, I can tell they meant a lot to you."*
- **Sometimes less is more:** Sometimes saying a simple "thank you for sharing" after each person has shared can be impactful and enough.

- **Workshops are not an art class:** avoid adding value to a participant's work by comparing or grading it.
 - *For example:* Saying a person's art is good, can also insinuate it can be bad.
- **Provide balanced responses:**
 - *For example:* If we tell a participant that we “love” what they created but do not say that to all of the participants, some may feel like their creations aren’t as valued as others.
- **Try Validation Only Responses:** avoid commenting on what someone might 'need to improve on' but rather what strengths we can see in the work.
 - *For example:* “I love the colors you chose,” “I love how you filled the page,” or “The textures you used really tell your story.” “I appreciate how you shared the art supplies.” “That's awesome you participated in a way that felt good / worked for you.”
- **Focus on process not appearance:** Share responses about participants' engaging in the creative process rather than how their art looks.
 - *For example:* “This is a window of time to listen to our heart, and honor whatever comes up, without judgment. Whether we tear up what we create or don’t create anything at all, it creates change and we are not the same afterwards and that, in and of itself, is art.”
- **Offer a breath and a word:** You can invite participants to take a breath after each person shares to pause and take in what was said. This can help participants and yourself stay in their bodies and connect. If you’d like, you can include a word that encapsulates what the person shared before the breath.
 - *For example:* If the person shared about imagination you can say “I invite everyone to take a breath for imagination” to pause and honor what that person said. That breath can provide a space for connection.
- **Tie in the workshop theme:**
 - *For example:* After each participant shares their Monster in Me creation, you can say, “I appreciate you sharing, your monster is welcome in this space.”
- **Responding to participants who prefer to Observe, Witness, and Listen:** There are many ways in which each individual participates throughout an art workshop. Some may share verbally, while others may choose to Observe, Witness, and Listen (OWL). All forms of participation are welcome and it’s important to respond and honor those who choose to observe and not share.
 - *For example:* “Thank you for honoring all of the ways you choose to participate today, including observing.”

Taking the necessary time to center yourself and your heart before bearing witness to a variety of experiences that participants share can open up the door to a more authentic response that is felt with the space. While we have put forward options for inviting and responding to participants sharing, we welcome you to go in whatever direction you feel will work best for you and your participants.